Is there any advantage in indicator sets being 'tidy' (for instance, five indicators grouped under five outcomes)?

Indicators sets may, or may not, be 'tidy'. For instance, a 'tidy' indicator set might contain five outcome areas and five indicators under each of these five outcome areas. You can be tempted to make your indicator sets look 'tidy' because indicator sets that are tidy look better and seem to be conceptually more 'organized'.

However, there is no reason to believe that indicators for a real-world organization, agency, provider, policy or initiative will turn out to be particularly tidy. Because of this, when you see a 'tidy' indicator set, it is likely that the different indicators listed under each of the outcome areas in such a set will not all be at the same levels within the relevant DoView strategy diagram/outcomes framework.

Such unnaturally 'tidy' indicator sets create a false sense of certainty for anyone using them. As in the case of the Proxy Indicator Level-Assessment Tool (D11), the solution to this problem is to be transparent about the level of the various indicators within your indicator set. You can do this by always showing your indicator set mapped against the boxes they measure within the relevant DoView strategy/outcomes diagram.

When presenting indicator sets in this way, you may see that some of the indicators that are being measured under some of the outcome areas are so low level that they are not really worth measuring. In such a case, they have just been included to create a 'tidy-looking' indicator set and are not adding any substantive analytical value.

Presenting your indicators against a DoView strategy/outcomes diagram means that those reading your indicator set can immediately 'see' the level of the boxes that particular indicators are measuring. They can also see any other, often higher-level boxes, which do not currently have any indicators. This means that the reader can work out whether the lower-level indicators being measured are providing sufficiently useful high-level strategic information. For quality strategic decision making, in contrast to being exclusively preoccupied with quantification, one may need to make judgment calls about how higher-level indicator-less boxes might be tracking. This is despite not being able to currently quantify them.

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